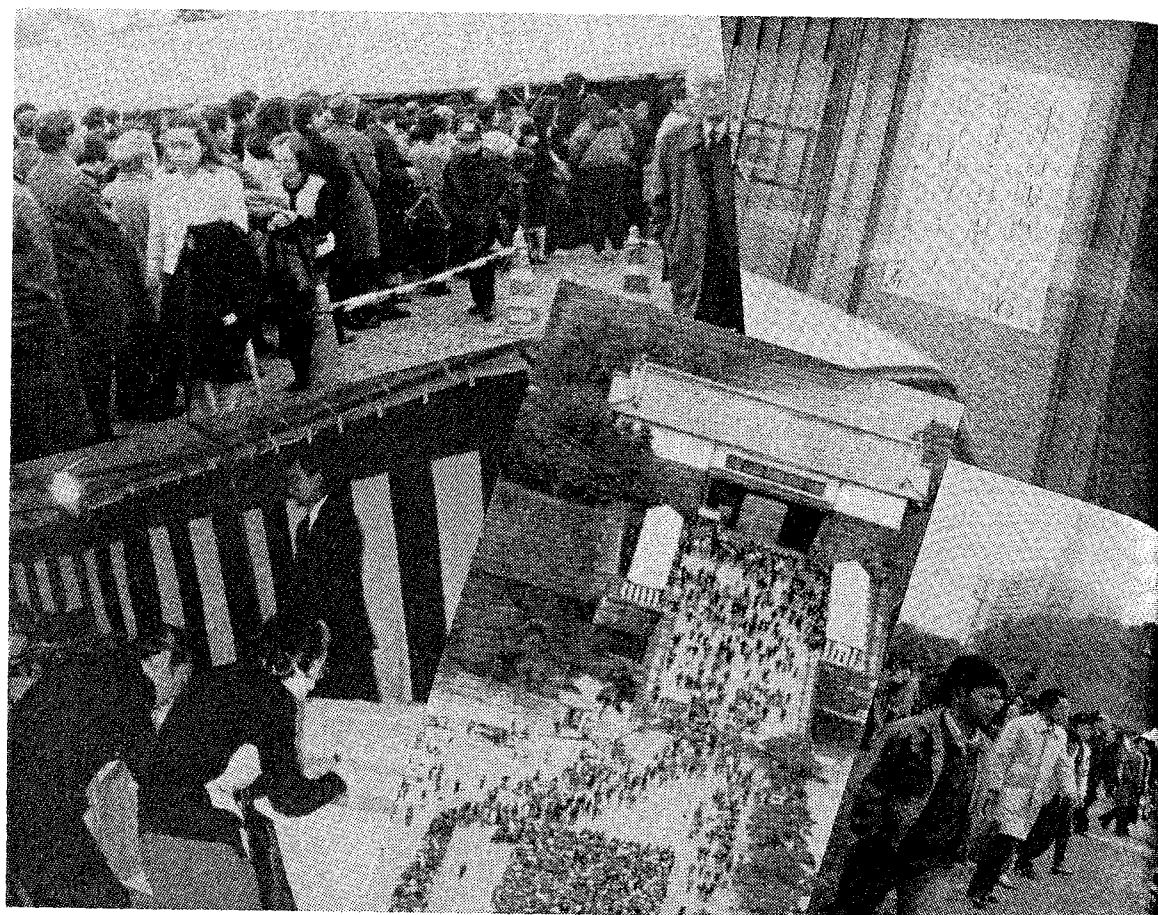




THE ROOTS OF SUBSERVIENCE

by Kan Takayuki

Kan Takayuki takes a long, hard look at the historical and cultural factors underlying the public reaction to the illness, death and funeral of Hirohito Tenno.

Well, as all the world now knows, the Showa Era came to an end when Hirohito Tenno (Emperor) died on January 7th, 1989, after a 111 day struggle with duodenal cancer following a collapse on September 19th, 1988. His passing, and the succession to the throne of Akihito Tenno, entailed a number of incidents which have thrown a question mark over the allegedly democratic nature of the Japanese state.

One of the most alarming aspects of Hirohito's illness, death and funeral was the atmosphere of *jishuku* or "self restraint" which manifested itself in the form of cancelled festivals, parties and other events to express concern for the tenno's illness. Self restraint is of course a peculiar piece of

doubletalk in this context, since most of the cancellations, postponements and toning down of operations were in fact not voluntary but imposed, often by local social groups or business mafia, who in turn were usually under pressure from the local police or from influential LDP members of local government.

A second aspect was the signing of condolence books by several million members of the Japanese public. Again the impression of a spontaneous response to the tenno's plight is false: the books were set up at the imperial palace and at government offices across the country, and there was a concerted campaign by prefectural and municipal authorities to get their people to sign

the dotted line. The campaign was initiated by the Ministry of Home Affairs, at the bidding of the then Prime Minister Takeshita Noboru.

A little paranoid, one might think. But not if one looks at the attitude taken by the LDP towards those unwilling to join in the Hirohito gloomfest: when members of the Saitama prefectural assembly started criticizing the prefecture's policy on self restraint and signing of well wishers' books, the LDP simply boycotted the session. A member of the Hokkaido assembly had a motion of censure passed against him for daring to bring up the tenno's war responsibility and the government's response to his illness in the course of debate. And so on.

These attacks on free speech often came close to red baiting, since the JCP (Communist Party) was the only opposition party to openly criticize the emperor in the Diet and local assemblies.

If that was bad, what followed the death of Hirohito was even worse. Flagrantly violating the constitutional separation of state and religion, the government held a succession ceremony for the new tenno which was at once a state function and a Shinto rite. Another traditional court ceremony, at which the new tenno addressed representatives of various walks of life, was also presented as a state sponsored event. And as for the funeral itself, no one was fooled by the government's ploy of holding two ceremonies in rapid succession: the Shinto *sojoden no gi* followed by a full dress state funeral at the same venue and before the same guests. The government's handling of events posed a clear threat to religious freedom and the sovereignty of the people in a supposedly secular state.

Equally questionable was the government's use of the police and armed forces to enforce its will over the tenno's funeral. Sixteen hundred Self Defense Force officials attended the state funeral as guards of honor, and SDF helicopters were used to fly in the VIPs. Since the SDF is of highly questionable constitutionality itself, their presence at the funeral spoke eloquently to the government's cavalier attitude towards the constitution.

Supporting the government in its bid to roll back the years to the days when the tenno ruled Japan was a shabby coalition of mass media, big business, the police and reactionary forces in the local communities, ultra-rightists, yakuza, and the like. The fact that no anti-tenno activists have been assassinated to date simply reflects the tight control which the police maintain on the far right in Japan.

The police in turn are controlled by the government, which hates to see international attention drawn to Japan's less savory aspects through acts of violence in the streets. Still, the

flood of threatening letters and phone calls to Nagasaki Mayor Motoshima Hitoshi and Meiji University President Morii Makoto, both critical of the tenno's role in the Pacific war, shows that the far rightists take their role as the government's bully boys quite seriously.

CROSSING THE STREET TOGETHER

And yet, and yet. Nice though it would be to blame the government for the whole Hirohito phenomenon, the fact remains that millions and millions of Japanese either willingly mourned and praised Hirohito, or gave in to government and media pressure to do so. The government made a disgrace of itself at the funeral, to be sure, but it could not have done so without a very considerable degree of public support. For ultimately, the power of the state depends on the support, or at least the tolerance, of the people. So here's the question we really need to address: why did so many fall in with the government line, sometimes even to the point of bullying or ignoring the minority who refused to do so?

Did they really believe in the divinity of the tenno, as in the bad old prewar years? Surely not. Or was this a purely involuntary response to pressure from the authorities? Again, surely not; there were enough exceptions around to show that the pressure could be resisted.

A better answer may be found in the culture and social structure of modern Japan, and its obsession with human relations based on uniform group behavior. The famous comedian Beat Takeshi put his finger on it when he said "If we all cross the road together, there's no need to be afraid of the red light." We feel safe and comfortable when they do things in a group, even things like ignoring traffic signals that we wouldn't want to do or dare to do on our own. Conversely, we feel uneasy when we do things which vary from the norm.

We make a virtue of this psychological weakness. People who are different, or who oppose the principle of sameness, are viewed not just as different but as fundamentally wrong. They bring ostracism and victimization down upon their own heads. In the end, same/different is the governing dichotomy of Japanese society.

It's got nothing to do with individual ethics, and everything to do with community morals. In rural society, here as elsewhere, harmony with one's neighbors was the supreme virtue. This, of course, reflected the need for coordination and equality in rural labor: one who worked too hard was considered as much of a social nuisance as one who was idle, and dissidents were thrown out of the community irrespective of ability. Today

agriculture is no longer Japan's main industry, and the rural community has largely been dismantled; the rural culture of human relations has proved far more resilient to the passing decades, however.

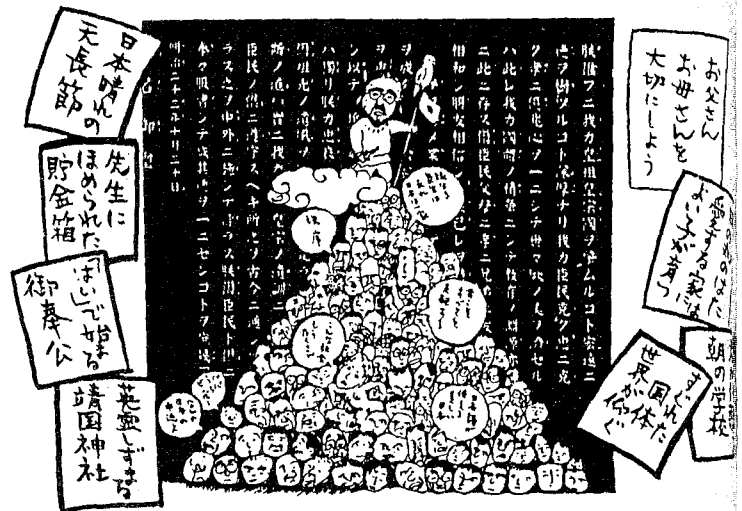
Why so resilient? Other countries had similar codes of conduct based on the agricultural way of life, but shed them as they industrialized. Japan's slowness to change probably reflects its relatively recent development of a capitalist economy and the rather unusual way in which that development was made.

In Britain, the society of citizens was established and dominated by the bourgeoisie, which used the monarchy to legitimize its rule. The French republic was founded in response to the people's demands manifested in the French Revolution. The United States was a nation forged through the War of Independence. What these widely differing nations had in common was that their political power as advanced capitalist nations was established by a bourgeois class which was already a recognizable social force. The prototype for the modern nation's value system was the bourgeois work ethic. Though tradition was respected to a degree, pre-modern value systems had to be remodeled before they could fit in with the rules of a society of citizens and the ideals of the nation state and become national value systems.

In Japan, by contrast, the modern state was formed through a coup d'etat by the lower ranks of the *samurai* class. Though the coup was supported by many farmers and merchants, the driving power came neither from the bourgeoisie nor from the landed gentry. Political power in the Meiji era was wielded by an autocracy which transcended class. It was this autocracy which modernized Japan, from the top down. The bourgeoisie was formed as one of the products of this modernization.

Consequently, the morals demanded of the people by the Meiji government were very different to those demanded by the governments of Europe and the United States. The ideals of the truly modern state of loyalty to the state based on the free will of independent and modern individuals had no place in Meiji Japan. Instead, the government demanded the morals of the former ruling class from politicians, bureaucrats, soldiers and technocrats, and the pre-modern morals of commoners from the rest of the people. Those in

power generally had no consciousness at all that their power derived from the will of the people while those not in power, the common people, were scarcely aware that they had rights. They never realized the difference between their political position in the feudal society run by the shoguns and in the modern state. Hence the people suffered from a lack of clarity in expressing their political will, and a reluctance to adopt positions on social issues which might jar with those perceived as



Tenno, poised at the pyramid's peak, reciting the Imperial Rescript on Education.

accepted by society at large.

Today the Japanese still lack some of the qualities necessary to become modern citizens: the true sense of the word; and the fault more surely lies in this peculiar style in which "modernization" has been achieved. The hierarchical system of feudal rural society lingered on in modern urban society, and obedience to that hierarchy has been made an essential virtue. Society resembles a great pyramid, composed of multitudes of smaller pyramids defined by hierarchy and discrimination. Within each pyramid there is a system of unlimited responsibility to those defined as insiders, and a corresponding system of irresponsibility to those defined as outsiders, as Maruyama Masao has pointed out.

IMPOSING HARMONY AND EXCLUSION

It may seem paradoxical to speak of hierarchy and discrimination in a society where conformity, sameness, is the greatest good. In fact, however, a philosophy of harmony and assimilation can only exist when people accept discrimination and hierarchy in every facet of social life. Acceptance is the key word. Japanese society is characterized not by outright oppression but by spontaneous harmony and willing acceptance of discrimination. The relationship between rulers and ruled is strikingly different to such relationships in the West.

Behind the outward appearance of a gentle and assimilating society lies a concealed inner system which suppresses conflict and contradiction through coercion and violence. Dissidents are put down not through state violence but through the sometimes violent hostility of their neighbors.

Which brings us back to Hirohito. The self restraint shown by the Japanese people during his terminal illness was not really voluntary but imposed: and imposed not so much by the state as by the system of conformity and tacit understanding running through social groups, local communities and society as a whole.

Do not disturb the harmony by making objections or drawing attention to discrimination this is the essence of human relations in the Japanese context. These principles apply to every decision making representative, from the prime minister to the leader of a labor union. A leader should not be a tyrant playing with power but a coordinator willing to respect customs. When trouble arises, the leader must work to coordinate views, smooth over differences, and save everybody's face. Once an agreement has been reached, however, it is ruthlessly enforced. The recent, admittedly unsuccessful, movement to remove the mayor of Beppu was a case in point. The mayor hadn't bothered to consult enough people before making policy decisions and consequently lost popularity.

What happens to stubborn individuals who simply refuse to accept collectively agreed decisions? They are branded as unfit to be members of the harmonious society and are, in one way or another, expelled from it. And in the case of political dissidents this doesn't just mean being regarded as an eccentric: it means being treated as an outright enemy of the state, by simple extension of the customs of a communal rural society. One's very existence can no longer be tolerated. It's a culture of exclusion, one aspect of Japanese society that the post war democratization could not change.

THE POST WAR TENNO

Japan's defeat in World War II brought sweeping changes to the constitution, to land ownership, to labor, education and the family. But these changes, without exception, were imposed from above, in this case by the occupation forces. And just as the modernization of the Meiji Era left a surprising number of old fashioned values intact or even strengthened, so the need to accept other people's reforms after the war reinforced the Japanese ethic of obedience and tacit understanding. The need to stay in line and not make waves seemed even more evident in the presence of a conquering power, and so the democratic reforms failed to bring with them a democratic spirit. Exclusion and discrimination remained the norm among a people which had been relieved of the responsibility to make its own decisions.

This is never more clearly seen than at election time. Even today, it is not uncommon for people to vote in accordance with instructions from some domestic power figure. My own mother-in-law and sister were ostracized by the local community for criticizing this custom back in the fifties. Bribery has remained a salient feature of election campaigns, and all too few people are willing to vote critically against it. Progressive political and social movements fight on, but have been eclipsed in the last twenty years.

In view of all this, it remains a moot point whether Japan can be better described as a republic or a monarchy. True, the tenno has no constitutional power, but his influence is far stronger and more pervasive than that would imply. Respect for the tenno is the ultimate expression of conformity in a society where that is the ultimate good. And so when he falls ill, a long line of well wishers forms outside the Imperial Palace, with some even going down on their knees to pray for his recovery. Across the nation, the people and their leaders mobilize for self restraint and woe betide those who see no need for it.

This is a cultural phenomenon. But the culture of conformity and exclusion which it expresses is something which moves Japanese politics at a deeper level than the rules written in the Constitution.

RELIGIOUS AND CULTURAL ROOTS

As I have pointed out, the Japanese culture of human relations has its origins in pre-modern, agricultural society. Society naturally reflects the prevailing mode of production

and labor, and when the people live by farming, hunting, fishing and forestry, the object of human labor is nature itself. Nature becomes an object of worship, too, an unknowable and awe inspiring thing without which human beings know only too well they could not survive. So it was in old Japan, where the people worshiped gods of mountains, lakes and seas, of animals and plants, even homelier gods embodied in earthenware ovens or places to defecate. The people tended not to make any clear cut distinction between nature and human beings; they felt themselves part of a single continuum of life.

In Islam, Allah, the notion of godhead, has struggles with nature, no doubt reflecting the struggle human beings have waged to survive in the harsh climate of the Middle East. In Japan, nature was kinder: a great provider whose fields, rivers, lakes, seas and mountains were a constant source of blessings to mankind. The occasional natural disasters were easily interpreted as warnings and punishments to humans who failed to show due respect for nature. Nature, in short, was the foundation of human life.

There is no evidence to show that the tenno had any place in this system of things until much later around the time of the first establishment of statehood in the 8th century. The pre-modern gods were nature spirits, not imperial ancestors. The introduction of Buddhism from China around the 6th century gave the people a secondary religion for use mainly at funerals, and again it was a religion unrelated to the tenno or his ancestors. The imperialistic doctrine of *honji suijaku* which held that Japan was created through a sort of joint effort between Buddha and Shinto gods appears to have found few takers in pre-modern times.

However, for a few centuries before the establishment of the Heian era (794-1191), a provincial king called *O Kimi* had been officiating as chief priest at agricultural rituals and other sacred rites. (see *AMPO* Vol. 17, No. 3 and No. 4) This was the predecessor of the tenno. Many historians believe that the ancestors of the imperial family came from the Asian continent, including not a few who subscribe to the controversial "horse rider theory," according to which the imperial ancestors were members of a tribe of horse riding nomads who came to Japan from the Korean peninsula. The very word *tenno* (emperor) is thought to have derived from the title of a certain kind of princely ruler in the hierarchy of Chinese taoism.

Be that as it may, the tenno's authority was established through his central position at harvest festivals, at which only members of the ruling class and a few special occupational groups were

allowed to take part. This exclusivity initially limited the degree to which the tenno could influence the peasant masses, but with the formation of the modern nation state, enormous power was to be concentrated in the role, though not the person, of the tenno.

In the Heian era, from the late 8th century, the authority of the tenno held sway mainly within the ranks of the ruling class. He played little part in the lives of those outside the aristocracy, except for a few exceptions such as shrine maidens who worshiped the imperial ancestors, ascetic monks who subscribed to a melange of Shintoist and Buddhist beliefs, certain craftsmen authorized by the tenno to travel and conduct business, and specially connected fishermen. For the peasant in the field, the tenno was of little significance.

Admittedly, there is some evidence to the contrary. In many areas of Japan there are legends and allegedly historical accounts claiming to show that families or tribes are descended from the imperial family, and there are tales of old battles, sermons and *kabuki* plays designed to stimulate interest in the tenno and respect for his authority. Some even appear to be based on respect for the tenno on the part of the masses themselves. But in reality, from the late Heian period (around the 11th century) to the final phase of the Edo period (mid 19th century), the tenno had virtually no political power. His authority was purely nominal, and what little political influence could be wielded by the tenno was obtained only in exchange for the practical benefit of legitimization by the tenno of the dominion of the actual rulers. The attachment to the tenno expressed by poets and storytellers, famous and anonymous alike, were no more than an oblique manifestation of hopes for an escape from the contradictions of oppressive government. It would be quite wrong to deduce significant political and social power on the part of the tenno from the historical record.

For all that, the maintenance by Japan's rulers of the semblance of imperial authority left open the possibility that one day, if the circumstances allowed, the tenno could become a center of real power. And that is exactly what has happened in the modern, tenno centered state.

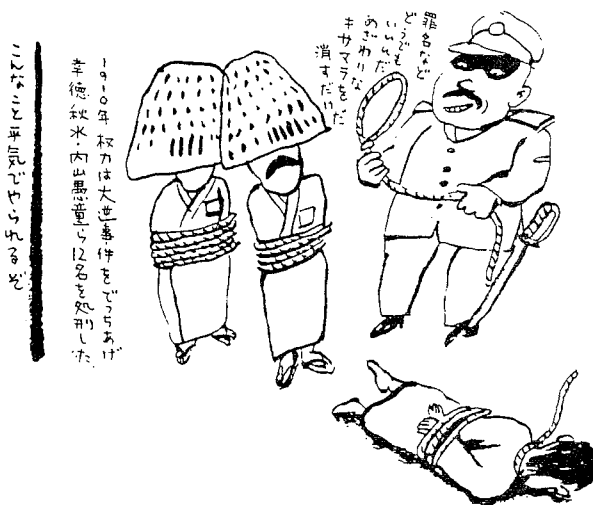
THE TENNO SYSTEM IN MEIJI JAPAN

The "nation state" established by the Meiji Restoration was a paradoxical affair. While attempting to create a truly modern nation, the restoration also sought to sweep away the power of the shogunate and its hierarchy of chieftains by restoring direct imperial rule, which had only previously prevailed, if ever, back in

8th century. The net result was the suppression of the utilitarian, rationalist element in late Edo period thought and its forced replacement, across the whole nation, with a reactionary zeal for return to a semi-mythical past.

This "modern" state did not recognize the sovereignty of the people; instead, the ludicrous notion of the tenno as living god was pressed on the people for the first time, and the tenno was set up as the foundation of the Japanese nation. One must stress that this obsession with the tenno only infected political thought in these far from ancient times.

The tenno-centered Meiji government instituted



In 1910 Kotoku Shusui, an anarchist, and 11 others were executed for an alleged plot to kill Taisho Tenno.

new land taxes en route to creating a centralized taxation system, revamped the army and inaugurated conscription, and executed a series of policies on education and religion which all helped consolidate the government's power and financial stability, and set the coercive apparatus of the state in place. At the center of this wide ranging operation was the drive to enforce belief in and respect for the tenno. This found its ultimate expression some twenty years after the Meiji Restoration in the Imperial Rescript to Soldiers and Sailors and the "granting" of the Meiji Constitution.

Buddhism was seen as a threat to the government's objectives, and was undermined by growing government support for Shinto shrines and for a growing government-led anti-Buddhist movement. As the years passed, a remarkably elaborate network was developed to drive the people to the shrines and worship the imperial ancestor/deities in them.

This ideology, imposed as it was from above,

found little resistance among the common people, for it meshed rather well with the people's group orientation, with all that that implied in terms of assimilation, discrimination and exclusion. The culture of assimilation and the rhetoric of tennoism were promoted by the government as a single entity, and together they played a decisive role in moulding the political and social consciousness of the ordinary people in modern Japan. The archaic ideology of 8th century Japan was put to work once more, this time as the driving ideology of a modern nation state. The people's daily worship of their local village deities blended with the worship of imperial deities, while the schools inculcated an intense desire for social climbing which proved quite compatible with Confucian type pragmatism and nationalism. From these various standpoints, the rulers threw their ideological net across the population.

"AGRICULTURE FIRST" AND OTHER CLOAKS OF TENNO DIVINITY

It wasn't an overnight transformation. Tenno worship didn't really take hold until the Russo Japanese War of 1904-5, and the system of tennoistic ethics, *shushin*, taught in the schools is not thought to have achieved

complete development until after 1906.

That tennoism did eventually achieve widespread acceptance owes much to economic and historical factors. Rural village life was gradually being eroded by modernization and the development of industrial capitalism, a trend which understandably instilled a deep sense of crisis among the peasantry. The conservative ideology of *nohon shugi*, agriculture first, with its simple, ecology oriented outlook, appealed to many of the common people as they confronted the collapse of a traditional way of life.

One might have expected this attitude to have led to dissatisfaction with the authorities and the tenno who embodied them. But here the tenno's origins as agricultural shaman, and the enduring emphasis on agricultural rites of state Shinto protected him. As *nohon shugi* become more and more anti-modern and anti-capitalist, so too its tennoist coloration became more pronounced.

And so the great paradox came to be: modernization was carried out in the name of the

tenno's authority, yet the tenno was not held to blame for the accompanying damage done to the traditional way of life. The tenno was seen as pro-agriculture, anti-modern and anti-capitalist. Later, in the hands of the propagandists, he would come to be seen as anti-Western, as supporting right against might, and so on. The evils of industrialization, modernization, capitalism and Western influence were blamed instead on "evil



As if in a street festival, he implores us to wear one of the masks and become truly Japanese.

advisers", a necessary part of every conservative tennoist's psychological furniture. These mental gymnastics could never have been performed without the incorporation of traditional agricultural mores into modern tennoism.

Not everyone lapped it up. As the social contradictions rooted in Meiji society became more blatant, a philosophy of civic rights and a movement to demand them came into being. These were repeatedly repressed by the authorities but repeatedly resurfaced, as demands for democracy or socialism, through the Meiji years. The thirst for democracy took root during the brief Taisho era that followed, a period still known today as the Taisho Democracy.

Tennoism took quite a battering in the Taisho years. It was well known that the Taisho Tenno (Yoshihito) suffered from a chronic brain disorder and was mentally incapable, making him a pretty inadequate object of worship. The rationalism of Taisho democracy came together with a popular

prejudice against those with disabilities to critically undermine the concept of the tenno as inviolable living god during the 1920's.

Which makes it all the more shocking, of course, that tennoism was to rise up with such a vengeance during the fifteen year war of the Showa era, from the Manchurian incident in 1931 to Japan's defeat in August 1945. The harsh lesson of history is that it doesn't really matter whether or not the people believe the tenno to be a god: the real issue is whether or not they can clearly state that he is not a god, rather than giving in to intimidation from their peers, "guidance" from authority figures or self interest to state otherwise. That, and whether or not society offers a material guarantee that those who do state clearly that the tenno is not a god will not end up being a small minority of martyrs. Japanese group ethics were found tragically lacking on these counts.

The "wisdom of the common people" was originally a pragmatic thing, a mindset adjusted to enable the people to live in harsh conditions. As such, it was not particularly susceptible to religious or ideological indoctrination, to the defense of an absolute faith, or to the idea that one might ever sacrifice one's life for an abstract principle. Conventional wisdom merely offers a few guidelines for enduring hardship and overcoming obstacles with the minimum of danger and the maximum of comfort and peace. So faced with such propositions as the tenno's divinity and the holiness of the Pacific War, most people decided whether or not to accept them on the simple pragmatic ground of whether or not it was to their advantage to do so.

A kind of "false obedience" was established on these pragmatic grounds, and a creeping process of indoctrination gradually stripped away the falsity to the point where the principle of obedience "began to walk on its own." And that was when tennoism became an active and dangerous faith. It was the young generation of tennoists, those born after 1920 or so, who took it most seriously, and they it was who went into the war head on, in the certainty that Japan was god's chosen country and could never be defeated. Older people did not as a rule share this crazed mystical nationalism, but they could do little more than look on helplessly from the sidelines as the tennoist ideology was inculcated ever more deeply into the minds of the young.

And so the ideology of the tenno, laughed at and despised by many, eventually took on a life and material force of its own as the ideology of the masses. Once established, the masses, driven ever by the wisdom of the group, could do no more than tag along.

CAN TENNOIST CULTURE BE DISMANTLED?

My conclusion is a pessimistic one in the short term, but filled with hope in the long run. Pessimistic, because the culture of personal relations which turned nearly all the Japanese people into war collaborators is still more or less intact. If intimidation or "guidance" is once again exerted to move the people in the direction of ultra nationalism, it is altogether possible that they might respond as before with a display of outward obedience, shading into genuine obedience in the ensuing generation. Certainly the circumstances are greatly changed today: there is no longer any material foundation for the "agriculture first" ideology, and the hard nosed materialism of today's Japan is scarcely conducive to belief in the tenno, or anyone else, as a god. But since self interest, rather than objective truth, remains the key criterion for judgment among Japanese adults, materialism and rationalism are not forces which can be relied on overly much. Besides, the modern communications systems of an information society make it that much easier to envelope the entire society in a lie disguised as a grand principle, and then to talk the populace to accept it as truth. Let us not underestimate the power of propaganda: a systematic program of brainwashing could stand Japanese society on its head within a couple of generations.

My hope for the longer term future stems from two factors which eventually will fatally weaken the tennoist ideology. One is the steady erosion of the foundations of the system of personal relations which has governed Japanese society for the past 120 years. It is a system rooted in agriculture, and Japanese agriculture, at least the variety that keeps the people close to nature, is a dying thing. Meanwhile, the desolation wrought upon Asia by the newly rich Japan is far too evident to allow Japanese ultra-nationalism to don the mantle of "Asian liberation" again. These factors, plus the continuing process of internationalization and the fundamental ridiculousness of the whole tennoist farrago, must surely lead to its demise in the not too distant future.

As tennoism finally withers away, the key question for Japan will be this: will we be able to dismantle the operative norms of assimilation, discrimination and exclusion which will linger on after the customs from which they grew have gone? Will we be able to replace them with new codes of behaviour, to create a society where every type of difference, whether of nationality, sex, or physical condition, will be treated as an opportunity for shared experience? Or will we allow the old norms to persist, so that with or

without the tenno system and state Shinto, the society which used them remains fundamentally unchanged? Any attempt to change Japanese society as it approaches the 21st century will be confronted with this question. Only by facing it and answering it will any social or political movement be able to change society at the levels that really matter.

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